The Big Over Easy

By Jasper Fforde

SPRATT: **(Pg 33)** *(to audience)* The yard was shaped as an oblong, surrounded by a high brick wall with crumbling mortar. At one end, where the dustbins were spilling their rubbish onto the ground, large pieces of eggshell told of a recent an violent death. The victim: Humpty Dumpty – under the jurisdiction of the Nursery Crime Division. *(DUM, DUM DUM DUM . . . DUM)*

INTRODUCTION

It's Easter in Reading --- a bad time for eggs. Nursery celebrity Humpty Dumpty is found shattered to death beneath a wall in a shabby area of town. And now it's up to Detective Jack Spratt and his new partner Mary Mary to solve the case. But Detective Spratt is fresh from a spectacular failure to convict three wily pigs for the murder of a certain wolf -- and the media and tide of public opinion are set squarely against him. Now new trouble is brewing . . The Big Over Easy by Jasper Fforde.

BRIGGS: **(Pg 33-35)** Looks like he died from injuries sustained falling from a wall. Could be accident, suicide, who knows? He was discovered dead at 0722 this morning.

4NG Fanatics

SPRATT: Anything else I need to know?

BRIGGS: You're not exactly 'Mr. Popular' at the present. There are people who think that spending a quarter of a million pounds on a failed murder conviction for three pigs is not value for money.

SPRATT: I didn't think justice was meant to have a price tag.

BRIGGS: It's a public-perception thing, Spratt. Piglets are cute; wolves aren't. You might as well try and charge the farmer's wife with cruelty when she cut off the mice's tails with a carving knife.

SPRATT: I did. *(beat)* Insufficient evidence.

BRIGGS: So . . . clean up Humpty's tumble with the minimum of fuss and bother. After that three-pigs debacle, I want it neat, quick and cheap. I want this ex-egg mopped up neat and clean and a report on my desk Wednesday morning. *(beckoning DS MARY over)* I want you to meet your new Detective Sergeant Mary. *(BRIGGS exits)*

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DS MARY: **(Pg 36)** *(very contrary to SPRATT)* Mary Mary. It's Mary Mary. That's my name.

SPRATT: **(Pg 42)** Detective Inspector Jack Spratt, Nursery Crime Division. **(Pg 57-58)** *(he launches unexcitedly into his usual induction speech as they both examine Humpy's body)* The NCD's jurisdiction covers all nursery characters. Because we cover well-established situations, patterns begin to emerge. There's usually a rule of three somewhere, as in beaus, billy goats, blind mice, little pigs. If you come across any stepmothers, they're usually evil, orphans are ten a penny, and pigs, cats, bears and wolves frequently anthropomorphize.

DS MARY: I wondered why Reading had talking animals.

SPRATT: The Billy Goats Gruff are a blast. I'll introduce you one day.

DS MARY: No troll?

SPRATT: In the clink. Eight-to-ten-year stretch for threatening behavior. *(beginning to brag)* **(Pg 62-63)** Did you hear about the time I saved Hansel and Gretel from being eaten alive by a witch?

DS MARY: No, I'm afraid I didn't.

4N6 Fanatics

SPRATT: Or the time I rescued a hundred children from the Pied Piper of Hamelin? *(a shake of the head)* Convicted Jill of aggravated assault against Jack?

DS MARY: Nope. *(SPRATT sigs heavily)* **(Pg 37)** *(MARY rolls her eyes, flips open a notepad, she speaks to the audience)* Humpty's ovoid body had fragmented almost completely. The night's heavy rain had washed away his liquid center, but there was sill an unmistakably eggy smell.

SPRATT: *(to audience)* A thin and hairless leg – still with shoe and sock. The biggest piece of shell contained Humpty's large features. His face was pale white. One of the eyes was open and a crack ran across his face.

DS MARY: The trauma was quite severe. An untrained eye might have dismissed his body as a heap of broken eggshell and a bundle of damp clothing. **(Pg 38)** How did you know him?

SPRATT: He used to lecture on children's literature at Reading University. Good company and very funny. **(Pg 39)** He was fired by the university in 1981 -- made the mistake of having an affair with the dean's wife, and it didn't go down too well. **(Pg 40)** *(looking up at the wall)*

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Humpty had always sat on walls, it was his way. *(returning to business)* We should have a word with Mrs. Dumpty.

******* Mrs. Dumpty's House*******

MRS. DUMPTY: (Pg 64) He had it coming. Who was it, a jealous husband?

SPRATT: We never said he was murdered, Mrs. Dumpty.

MRS. DUMPTY: (Pg 66-67) We lived together for eighteen years. His philandering got worse. I through it would blow over, small indiscretions that only served to prove he could still charm the ladies. It carried on, grew more and more blatant. *(shrugs her shoulders)* I changed the locks. Got a divorce.

SPRATT: Did he ever get depressed?

MRS. DUMPTY: *(she is visibly moved)* Depressed? Are you considering this might be suicide? *(then with haughty indifference)* He often got depressed. He was an outpatient at St. Cerebellum's for longer than I had known him. Easter was always bad for him, as you can imagine. Sometime he would wake up at night in a sweat screaming, "Help, Help, Take me off, I'm boiling!" **(Pg 112)** A recurring nightmare of being boiled alive for

4NG Fanatics

exactly three minutes. **(Pg 67)** *(DS MARY laughs and tries to disguise it as a sneeze)* I'm sorry, Officer, do you find something funny? *(she is done)* If you have no other questions . . . *(she sees them out)*

DS MARY: Think she's over Dumpty?

SPRATT: Not really. I think she had Secrets. Perhaps not to do with his death, but secrets nonetheless.

******** NEWS BREAK*******

ANNOUNCER: (Pg 107) [This just in . . .] The Reading genetic industry suffered a severe blow last night when the Quatt Foundation for Genetic Research was closed following its owner's admission that she conducted morally dubious experiments. The disgraced Dr. Quatt has been permanently banned from funded research and has been shunned by every hospital in the nation, except for St. Cerebellum's.

****** At St. Cerebellum's Mental Hospital *******

NURSE: (Pg 108) *(escorting SPRATT and DS MARY to DR. QUATT's OFFICE)* Dr. Quatt is a brillian woman. Mad as a barrel of skunks, and many people see her as a perverter of all decent virtues . . . but they said the same about Galileo *(she laughs)* All her work was to alleviate

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suffering. When they banned her, a dark veil fell over the medical research community. We don't expect outsiders to ***truly*** understand her brilliance.

SPRATT: **(Pg 110-112)** Dr. Deborah Quatt? We wanted to talk to you about one of your patients – a Mr. Dumpty. You do know that he's dead.

DR. QUATT: *(haughtily and a bit crazy)* I was nowhere near him. If you want to try me for malpractice, you'll have to mount a good case. I've plenty of experience defending them, believe you me. *(adjusting her tone)* Mr. Dumpty? Dead? What a pity. (she looks around, lowers her voice) Did you know that I have successfully grafted a kitten's head onto a haddock? *(back to crazy)* It's not against the law. I just can't get any funding to do proper research because of damnable outdated moral principles. In the world of cutting-edge genetic research, you can't make an omelet without breaking eggs.

SPRATT: Which brings us back to Mr. Dumpty. How long had you been his doctor?

DR. QUATT: For five years. I was a psychiatrist before I moved into genetic research . . .

SPRATT: When did you last see him?

4NG Fanatics

DR. QUATT: Six days ago. Easter was a bad time for him, as you can imagine, with all those chocolate eggs being eaten and real ones dyed – he was a virtual prisoner in his own home.

SPRATT: **(Pg 113)** Thank you, Dr. Quatt. Tell me – and this is just personal curiosity – were you serious when you said you'd grafted a kitten's head onto a haddock?

DR. QUATT: *(crazy returns)* Do you want to see?

SPRATT: **(Pg 132-133)** *(his phone rings, he answers, listens, then hangs up) Got* a problem with morgues, Mary? [Time to] view some corpses.

*****NEWS BREAK*****

ANNOUNCER: [This just in . . .]**(Pg 92)** The incredibly dangerous homicidal maniac known as "The Gingerbreadman" was captured last night. The flour, butter, ginger and sugar psychopath, **(Pg 109)** with cherry eyes and thin licorice lips, **(Pg 92)** whose penchant for literally pulling his victims apart, is currently in a secure wing of St. Cerebellum's **(Pg 107)** mental hospital, **(Pg 92)** where he will doubtless remain for the rest of his life.

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(SPRATT and MARY enter the morgue)

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DS MARY: **(Pg 133)** An ordinary pathologist would have given Humpty the most cursory of glances, but Mrs. Singh was different.

SPRATT: *(to SINGH in admiration)* So you've managed to do what all the king's men couldn't.

SINGH: *(proudly)* One hundred and twenty-six pieces! They say dead men can't talk, but this one has spoken volumes. Take a look. *(She turns Humpty's reconstructed body over)* Look at the damage on the lower back.

SPRATT: **(Pg 134)** *(whispering)* Holy s***. He was . . . shot.

SINGH: The discoloration is gunshot residue. Someone came up from the other side of the wall and shot him. By the time the bullet exited, the cracks had already encircled his body and . . . pow! -- Exploded. *(beat)* **(Pg 135)** There was one thing that puzzled me, though. *(she points to the body)* This section of shell, here on his waistline – or neckline, if you prefer. A small hole exactly one-quarter inch in width. Drilled in him – and deliberately too. There was a Band-Aid covering it.

SPRATT: Drug abuse?

SINGH: Possibly. I've run the usual tests. I'll let you know as soon as I have something.

4NG Fanatics

SPRATT: **(Pg 137)** Humpty didn't fall, and he didn't jump. Mary, we should speak to his ex-wife again. *(SPRATT and MARY exit)*

DS MARY: **(Pg 174)** *(her phone rings)* Thanks for calling. We'll be straight there. *(she hangs up)* It's Mrs. Dumpty. There's been an accident. She's. . . dead.

*****At the offices of Yummy-Time*****

EXECUTIVE: **(Pg 176-177)** *(obviously distraught)* She'd been a leading light of Yummy-Time since she took over from her father ten years ago. She knew shortbread fingers like the back of her hand. Mr. Aimsworth said he saw her jump into the main dough mixer. *(a muffled sob)*

SPRATT: I'm going to look at her office. *(They enter the office and SPRATT speaks to the audience as he walks to the desk)* A picture of her and Humpty in a gilt frame. And there, on the blotter, was a single piece of paper folded once, with [my] name written clearly on the front. *(he dons gloves, opens the note and reads it aloud)* "DI Spratt – What I did was out of love, not hate. We had been moving towards a reconciliation, until I saw him with a bimbo and my bod boiled. I went to his home and prayed

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for God to forgive me as I pulled the trigger. – Signed Laura Dumpty"

DS MARY: So she ***did*** kill him.

SPRATT: **(Pg 178)** It seems a bit too perfect. *(Spratt's phone rings, he answers and puts her on speaker)*

SINGH: **(Pg 363-365)** I've been trying to reach you all day! I got Humpty's results back from the Sunny Dale Poultry Labs. Traces of chorioallatonic membrane.

SPRATT: Traces of what?

SINGH: Chorioallatonic membrane. It's a highly vascularized extra-embryonic membrane that functions as a site for nutrient transport and waste disposal during embryonic development!

SPRATT: Embryonic development? You mean . . .

SINGH: Right. He didn't die from the gunshot wound or the fall. He ***hatched***.

SPRATT: Humpty Dumpty was ***pregnant***?

SINGH: Pregnant is perhaps the wrong word. He was an egg . . . and eggs, when fertilized, hatch.

DS MARY: Wait a minute, wait a minute. He's a guy, right? Over sixty-five years of age., so I think we can safely say

4NG Fanatics

he was born – laid – whatever – unfertilized. So when ***was*** he fertilized?

SINGH: By comparing the volume of his egg, we can safely say . . . about six months ago.

SPRATT: How?

SINGH: The hole I found drilled in his shell. A modified IVF procedure would do the trick.

SPRATT: But it's still murder. Whatever grew inside him would have been slowly consuming him from within. The question is WHY?

DS MARY: I should imagine the poultry industry might be very interested in a three-ton chicken, sir.

SPRATT: Don't be ridiculous, Mary. You'd never find an oven big enough. Besides, what misbegotten evil genius would be so cruelly insane as to want to carry out such a bizarre and perverted experiment on a living breathing creature?

DS MARY: Dr. Quatt!

SPRATT: She had the opportunity, the skill, the knowledge. But, more important, the total absence of any ethical standards! Take a couple of officers and go to St. Cerebellum's to arrest Dr. Quatt. [I'll] call the Ops room

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and see if anyone has reported seeing a giant chicken loose in Reading! *(DUM, DUM DUM DUM . . . DUM)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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